Computational Economics

Lecture: Value Functions and the Bellman Equation

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Lecture Overview

- **The Value Function**
  - MDPs, policy rollouts, and discounted rewards
  - Expected return from a starting state
- **The Bellman Equation**
  - Recursive returns and the policy Bellman equation
  - Policy evaluation as a linear system
  - Optimal value and Bellman optimality
- **Value Function Iteration**
  - The Bellman operator and convergence
  - Iteration, stopping criteria, and policy recovery
  - Finite-horizon backward induction

Recap: A Markov Decision Process

A time-homogeneous discounted **MDP** is specified by $(\mathcal{S}, \{\mathcal{A}(s)\}_{s\in\mathcal{S}}, P, r, \beta)$.

- **State space $\mathcal{S}$:** free cells $\mathcal{S} = \{\mathrm{S}, \mathrm{G}, 1, \ldots, 45\}$, including G. Walls are excluded.
- **Actions $\mathcal{A}(s)$:** up, down, left, right.
- **Transition kernel $P(s' \mid s, a)$:** probability 1 for the cell reached by action a, and 0 for all other cells. For example, $P(21 \mid \mathrm{S}, \text{down}) = 1$. A wall or boundary keeps the current cell; G is absorbing.
- **Mean reward $r(s, a)$:** -1 per move from outside G (including entry into G); zero at G.
- **Discount factor $\beta \in (0, 1)$:** weights future rewards.

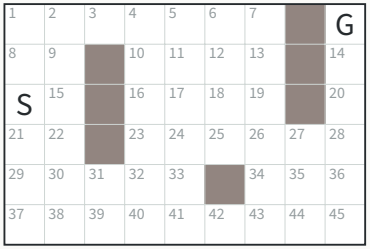


Figure 1: Maze navigation.

Recap: A Policy Chooses an Action at Each State

A **stationary deterministic policy** is a rule σ with $\sigma(s) \in \mathcal{A}(s)$: at cell s, take action $a = \sigma(s)$.

$\sigma_A = (\text{S} \to \text{down},\ \text{cell } 21 \to \text{down},\ \text{cell } 29 \to \text{right}, \ldots)$

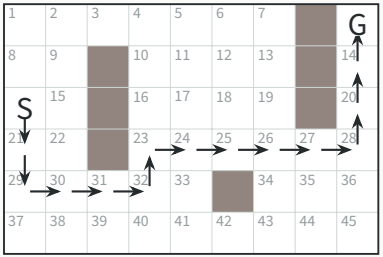


Figure 2: Policy σ_A.

$\sigma_B = (\text{S} \to \text{up},\ \text{cell } 8 \to \text{up},\ \text{cell } 1 \to \text{right}, \ldots)$

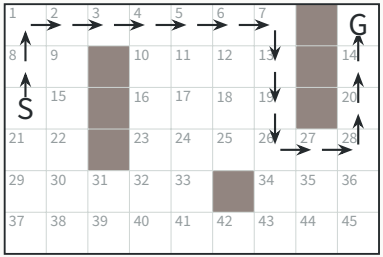


Figure 3: Policy σ_B.

Rollouts: Simulating a Policy

In reinforcement learning, a **rollout** follows a policy from a starting state, generating a **trajectory** of states, actions, and rewards.

To simulate a rollout from $s_t = s$, repeat for $\tau = 1, 2, \ldots$:

$$a_{t+\tau-1} = \sigma(s_{t+\tau-1}), \qquad s_{t+\tau} \sim P(\cdot \mid s_{t+\tau-1}, a_{t+\tau-1}).$$

The environment also generates reward $R_{t+\tau}$, whose conditional mean is $r(s_{t+\tau-1}, a_{t+\tau-1})$.

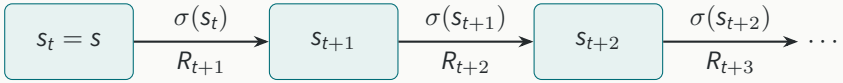


Figure 4: A rollout under policy σ.

The associated **reward stream** is $R_{t+1}, R_{t+2}, \ldots$. Rollouts can differ when transitions or rewards are random.

The Return of a Rollout

The **discounted accumulated reward**, or **return**, assigns a number to the reward stream of a rollout starting at date t:

$$G_t = R_{t+1} + \beta R_{t+2} + \cdots + \beta^{\tau-1} R_{t+\tau} + \cdots = \sum_{\tau=1}^{\infty} \beta^{\tau-1} R_{t+\tau}.$$

Example: Maze Escape

The two policies generate deterministic rollouts reaching G after 14 and 16 moves. Each move earns -1; rewards are zero after reaching G.

With $\beta = 0.9$,

$$G_t^{\sigma_A} = -\sum_{\tau=1}^{14} 0.9^{\tau-1} \approx -7.71, \qquad G_t^{\sigma_B} = -\sum_{\tau=1}^{16} 0.9^{\tau-1} \approx -8.15.$$

A return describes one rollout. To evaluate a policy, we will consider the expected return over its possible rollouts.

Discounting and a Finite Return

Let $\bar{r} < \infty$ be a **uniform bound on absolute rewards**: $|R_{t+j}| \leq \bar{r}$ for every $j \geq 1$.

For any rollout truncated after τ periods,

$$\left|G_t^{(\tau)}\right| = \left|\sum_{j=1}^{\tau} \beta^{j-1} R_{t+j}\right| \leq \sum_{j=1}^{\tau} \beta^{j-1} |R_{t+j}|$$
$$\leq \bar{r} \sum_{j=1}^{\tau} \beta^{j-1} = \frac{1-\beta^{\tau}}{1-\beta}\, \bar{r}.$$

As $\tau \to \infty$, $\beta^{\tau} \to 0$, so the infinite-horizon return satisfies

$$|G_t| \leq \lim_{\tau \to \infty} \frac{1-\beta^{\tau}}{1-\beta}\, \bar{r} = \frac{\bar{r}}{1-\beta}.$$

Example: Two Cake-Eating Rollouts

Example: Cake Eating

Start with two units of cake. For this example, restrict stock and consumption to whole units:

$$k \in \{0, 1, 2\}, \quad c \in \{0, \ldots, k\}, \quad k' = k - c, \quad r(k, c) = \sqrt{c}, \quad \beta = 0.9.$$

Consume everything: $\sigma_A(k) = k$

$$k_t, k_{t+1}, k_{t+2}: \quad 2 \longrightarrow 0 \longrightarrow 0$$

$$R_{t+1}, R_{t+2}, \ldots: \quad \sqrt{2},\ 0,\ 0, \ldots$$

$$G_t = \sqrt{2} \approx 1.414.$$

One unit at a time: $\sigma_B(k) = \min\{1, k\}$

$$k_t, k_{t+1}, k_{t+2}: \quad 2 \longrightarrow 1 \longrightarrow 0$$

$$R_{t+1}, R_{t+2}, \ldots: \quad 1,\ 1,\ 0, \ldots$$

$$G_t = 1 + 0.9 = 1.9.$$

Each policy produces a deterministic rollout. A smaller reward at the first step can lead to a larger return.

The Value Function of a Policy

The **state-value function under policy** σ is the expected return over rollouts starting at s. With time-homogeneous dynamics and a stationary policy, it does not depend on the starting date t:

$$V^{\sigma}(s) = \mathbb{E}_{\sigma}[G_t \mid s_t = s] = \mathbb{E}_{\sigma}\left[\sum_{\tau=1}^{\infty} \beta^{\tau-1} R_{t+\tau} \,\middle|\, s_t = s\right].$$

- G_t is the return of one rollout. $V^{\sigma}(s)$ averages over all possible rollouts from s under σ.
- Since $r(s, a)$ is the conditional mean reward, boundedness also gives

$$V^{\sigma}(s) = \mathbb{E}_{\sigma}\left[\sum_{\tau=1}^{\infty} \beta^{\tau-1} r(s_{t+\tau-1}, \sigma(s_{t+\tau-1})) \,\middle|\, s_t = s\right].$$

- For the cake example, $V^{\sigma_A}(2) = \sqrt{2}$ and $V^{\sigma_B}(2) = 1.9$.

The Return Has a Recursive Form

Along a rollout, the return from date t is:

$$G_t = R_{t+1} + \beta R_{t+2} + \beta^2 R_{t+3} + \cdots .$$

Separate the first reward from all later rewards:

$$\begin{aligned} G_t &= R_{t+1} + \beta\big(R_{t+2} + \beta R_{t+3} + \cdots\big) \\ &= R_{t+1} + \beta G_{t+1}. \end{aligned}$$

- G_{t+1} is the return from the remainder of the same rollout.
- With time-homogeneous dynamics and a stationary policy,

$$\mathbb{E}_\sigma[G_{t+1} \mid s_{t+1} = s'] = V^\sigma(s').$$

This lets us replace an infinite reward sequence with a one-step equation.

The Bellman Equation for a Fixed Policy

Average the rollout identity $G_t = R_{t+1} + \beta G_{t+1}$ conditional on $s_t = s$:

$$\begin{aligned} V^\sigma(s) &= \mathbb{E}_\sigma[R_{t+1} + \beta G_{t+1} \mid s_t = s] \\ &= r(s, \sigma(s)) + \beta \mathbb{E}[V^\sigma(s_{t+1}) \mid s_t = s,\ a_t = \sigma(s)]. \end{aligned}$$

The second equality uses the law of iterated expectations and the Markov structure.

For a finite state space, the **policy Bellman equation** is

$$V^\sigma(s) = r(s, \sigma(s)) + \beta \sum_{s' \in \mathcal{S}} P(s' \mid s, \sigma(s)) V^\sigma(s').$$

Current expected reward plus discounted expected continuation value. For a continuous state space, replace the sum by an integral with respect to $P(ds' \mid s, \sigma(s))$.

Policy Evaluation as a Linear System

From here, assume $\mathcal{S}$ and each nonempty $\mathcal{A}(s)$ are finite.

Fix σ. Recall its induced transition matrix and reward vector:

$$P^{\sigma}_{ij} = P(j \mid i, \sigma(i)), \qquad r^{\sigma}_{i} = r(i, \sigma(i)).$$

Treat V^{σ} and r^{σ} as **column vectors**. Then

$$V^{\sigma} = r^{\sigma} + \beta P^{\sigma} V^{\sigma} \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad (I - \beta P^{\sigma}) V^{\sigma} = r^{\sigma}.$$

- P^{σ} is row-stochastic, so $\beta < 1$ makes $I - \beta P^{\sigma}$ invertible:

$$V^{\sigma} = \sum_{\tau=1}^{\infty} \beta^{\tau-1} (P^{\sigma})^{\tau-1} r^{\sigma} = (I - \beta P^{\sigma})^{-1} r^{\sigma}.$$

- In code, solve the linear system rather than forming the inverse.

Example: Income Along an Employment Chain

Example: Employment and Unemployment

Take the earlier employment dynamics as given, and attach income 0 in U and 1 in E. There is no action choice in this calculation.

$$P = \begin{pmatrix} 0.8 & 0.2 \\ 0.05 & 0.95 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad r = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \beta = 0.9.$$

Rollouts generate random income streams. Their expected returns solve

$$V(\mathrm{U}) = 0 + 0.9\big[0.8V(\mathrm{U}) + 0.2V(\mathrm{E})\big],$$
$$V(\mathrm{E}) = 1 + 0.9\big[0.05V(\mathrm{U}) + 0.95V(\mathrm{E})\big].$$

$$V(\mathrm{U}) = \frac{72}{13} \approx 5.538, \qquad V(\mathrm{E}) = \frac{112}{13} \approx 8.615.$$

- Unemployment has positive value because future employment is possible.
- Employment is worth less than $1/(1-0.9) = 10$, because job loss is possible.

Iterative Policy Evaluation

We can also compute V^σ by repeated substitution, keeping σ fixed:

$$v^{(n+1)} = r^\sigma + \beta P^\sigma v^{(n)}, \qquad v^{(0)} = 0.$$

- Use the old vector $v^{(n)}$ for every state in a sweep.
- After n sweeps, $v^{(n)}$ is the expected return of an n-step rollout under σ, with zero value beyond it.

For the employment example:

$$v^{(0)} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad v^{(1)} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad v^{(2)} = \begin{pmatrix} 0.180 \\ 1.855 \end{pmatrix}, \quad v^{(n)} \longrightarrow \begin{pmatrix} 5.538\ldots \\ 8.615\ldots \end{pmatrix}.$$

n counts computational iterations. The policy being evaluated does not change.

From Policy Values to the Optimal Value

Let Σ be the set of feasible stationary deterministic policies. Define the **optimal value function** by

$$V^*(s) = \max_{\sigma \in \Sigma} V^\sigma(s).$$

- A policy σ^* is **optimal** if it achieves this value at every state:

$$V^{\sigma^*}(s) = V^*(s) \qquad \text{for every } s \in \mathcal{S}.$$

- In a finite, time-homogeneous discounted MDP, such a stationary deterministic policy exists. Allowing randomized or history-dependent policies cannot improve the value.
- The policy may be nonunique when several actions are equally good.

The task now is to choose the policy with the highest expected rollout return from each state.

The Bellman Optimality Equation

The **principle of optimality**: after the next state is observed, an optimal policy uses an optimal continuation from that state.

Choose the current action a, then continue optimally. Its expected return is

$$r(s,a) + \beta \sum_{s'} P(s' \mid s,a) V^*(s').$$

Maximizing over the feasible current actions gives the **Bellman optimality equation**:

$$V^*(s) = \max_{a \in \mathcal{A}(s)} \left\{ r(s,a) + \beta \sum_{s'} P(s' \mid s,a) V^*(s') \right\}.$$

- The current action is chosen before the random next state is observed.
- Future actions can respond to that realized state. $V^*(s')$ includes all those later choices.

Example: The Cake-Eating Bellman Equation

Example: Cake Eating

Use the same whole-unit model, $k \in \{0, 1, 2\}$ and $\beta = 0.9$:

$$V^*(k) = \max_{c \in \{0,\dots,k\}} \{\sqrt{c} + 0.9V^*(k-c)\}.$$

At zero stock, $V^*(0) = 0.9V^*(0)$, so $V^*(0) = 0$. At one unit,

$$V^*(1) = \max\{0.9V^*(1),\ 1\} = 1.$$

At two units, check all three feasible actions:

$$V^*(2) = \max\{\underbrace{0.9V^*(2)}_{c=0},\ \underbrace{1 + 0.9V^*(1)}_{c=1},\ \underbrace{\sqrt{2}}_{c=2}\} = 1.9.$$

- At this solution, the three candidate values are $1.71, 1.9, 1.414\ldots$.
- Thus $\sigma^*(2) = 1$, $\sigma^*(1) = 1$, and $\sigma^*(0) = 0$.

The Bellman Operator

An **operator** maps a candidate value function v to a new function.

$$(Tv)(s) = \max_{a \in \mathcal{A}(s)} \left\{ r(s,a) + \beta \sum_{s'} P(s' \mid s,a) v(s') \right\}.$$

- $v(s')$ is our current assessment of future states. Tv updates that assessment using the best current action.
- Holding a policy fixed instead gives

$$(T^\sigma v)(s) = r(s,\sigma(s)) + \beta \sum_{s'} P(s' \mid s,\sigma(s)) v(s').$$

- A **fixed point** is unchanged by its operator:

$$V^* = TV^*, \qquad V^\sigma = T^\sigma V^\sigma.$$

Why the Iteration Converges

Use the **maximum norm** $\|v - w\|_\infty = \max_s |v(s) - w(s)|$. For any state and action,

$$\left| \beta \sum_{s'} P(s' \mid s, a) \big[v(s') - w(s') \big] \right| \le \beta \|v - w\|_\infty .$$

Taking the maximum over actions preserves this bound, since $|\max_a x_a - \max_a y_a| \le \max_a |x_a - y_a|$. Hence

$$\|Tv - Tw\|_\infty \le \beta \|v - w\|_\infty .$$

- T is a **contraction**: the new distance is at most $\beta < 1$ times the old distance.
- On the finite-dimensional value space, it has a unique fixed point V^*, and

$$\|T^n v^{(0)} - V^*\|_\infty \le \beta^n \|v^{(0)} - V^*\|_\infty .$$

- The same argument applies to T^σ and its fixed point V^σ.

Value Function Iteration

Given the finite MDP and a desired value-error tolerance $\varepsilon > 0$:

1. Choose $v^{(0)}$, for example zero, and set $n = 0$.
2. Update every state using the previous vector:

$$v^{(n+1)}(s) = (Tv^{(n)})(s) = \max_{a \in \mathcal{A}(s)} \left\{ r(s,a) + \beta \sum_{s'} P(s' \mid s,a) v^{(n)}(s') \right\}.$$

3. Calculate the **Bellman residual** of $v^{(n)}$:

$$d_n = \|Tv^{(n)} - v^{(n)}\|_\infty = \|v^{(n+1)} - v^{(n)}\|_\infty.$$

4. If $d_n \leq (1-\beta)\varepsilon$, return $v^{(n)}$. Otherwise increase n and repeat.

The contraction inequality implies

$$\|v^{(n)} - V^*\|_\infty \leq \frac{d_n}{1-\beta} \leq \varepsilon.$$

This bound assumes exact expectations and maximization in the specified finite model.

Example: Value Iteration for Cake Eating

Example: Cake Eating

Start from $v^{(0)}(k) = 0$, using $\beta = 0.9$.

	Stock 0	Stock 1	Stock 2
$v^{(0)}$	0	0	0
$v^{(1)} = Tv^{(0)}$	0	1	$\sqrt{2} \approx 1.414$
$v^{(2)} = Tv^{(1)}$	0	1	1.9
$v^{(3)} = Tv^{(2)}$	0	1	1.9

- The first update assigns zero continuation value, so consuming everything looks best.
- In the second update, saving one unit has value:

$$1 + 0.9v^{(1)}(1) = 1.9 > \sqrt{2}.$$

- A further update leaves the vector unchanged: the Bellman residual is zero.

A Finite Horizon: Backward Induction

If decisions end at date $H-1$, let $h(s_H)$ be a terminal payoff at date H. The objective from $s_t = s$ is

$$\max_{\sigma_t,\ldots,\sigma_{H-1}} \mathbb{E}\left[\sum_{\tau=1}^{H-t} \beta^{\tau-1} R_{t+\tau} + \beta^{H-t} h(s_H) \,\middle|\, s_t = s\right].$$

Backward induction starts at the terminal date and works toward the present:

$$V_H(s) = h(s),$$

$$V_t(s) = \max_{a \in \mathcal{A}(s)} \left\{ r(s,a) + \beta \sum_{s'} P(s' \mid s,a) V_{t+1}(s') \right\}, \quad t = H-1, \ldots, 0.$$

- The remaining horizon changes with t; optimal decision rules can depend on time.
- With $h = 0$, $T^H 0$ is the value with H decisions remaining. This also explains the earlier cake iterations.

Recovering a Policy from Values

Once we have V^*, choose an action that attains its Bellman maximum:

$$\sigma^*(s) \in \arg\max_{a \in \mathcal{A}(s)} \left\{ r(s,a) + \beta \sum_{s'} P(s' \mid s,a) V^*(s') \right\}.$$

- A **greedy policy with respect to** v uses the same expression with a candidate value v in place of V^*.
- With an approximate value, the resulting policy is a candidate. Evaluate it by solving

$$(I - \beta P^\sigma) V^\sigma = r^\sigma.$$

- The value function summarizes future rewards; the policy specifies the action to take. Computing both makes the solution usable.

References and Further Reading

1. **Richard S. Sutton and Andrew G. Barto (2018), Reinforcement Learning: An Introduction. 2nd ed. MIT Press. [Book]**
   - Chapter 3: Finite Markov Decision Processes (Sections 3.3, 3.5 and 3.6)
   - Chapter 4: Dynamic Programming (Sections 4.1 and 4.4)
   - Section 8.10: Rollout Algorithms
2. **Thomas J. Sargent and John Stachurski, QuantEcon. [Online lectures]**
   - Discrete State Dynamic Programming
3. **Feng (2026), Foundations of Macroeconomics: ECON 282E, Fall 2026. [Online course]**
   - Session 1, Deck 1.B2: Dynamic Programming: Why It Works and How It Computes